

Above and beyond

BUILDING WORLD-CLASS DRONES IN INDIA

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In a glass-walled conference room perched above Mumbai's traffic-choked sprawl, Ankit Mehta doesn't look like a man operating at drone-speed. Calm, unhurried, but intensely lucid in thought, the CEO and co-founder of ideaForge speaks like someone who knows his machines have nothing left to prove. "We always aim and attempt to make the best drones in the world," he says flatly. It's a claim few Indian technology founders would make – fewer still with the receipts to back it up. So it's definitely impressive.

According to Ankit Mehta, the story of ideaForge begins with a detour. "We essentially started building drones as a team way back in 2004," Mehta recalls. One of his co-founders wanted to build a hovercraft for fun. Instead, the team pivoted to quadcopters, cobbling together a prototype years before DIY drone kits and FPV YouTube channels would become a thing. "From '04 till '08, we were more like having fun with technology," he says. But by 2008, the fun got serious.

That year, ideaForge delivered what Mehta claims was "the world's smallest and lightest autopilot" to Indian defense and civil research labs. It predates even the earliest open-source drone autopilots that became globally recognized a year later. "Every line of the code has been written by us," he says of ideaForge's flight controllers, the beating heart of their autonomous systems. Not

many can say that out loud.

By the time the 2008 Mumbai terror attacks took place, Mehta and his co-founders had already been pulled into the security domain. They saw helicopters being used to peer into buildings and thought, drones should be doing that. "That's what triggered us to build the quadcopter drones we launched in 2009," Mehta says. The company's first sale followed in 2010. Fast forward to today, ideaForge drones have flown over 650,000 missions, with one taking off every three minutes for either security or geospatial use.

Here's the thing about ideaForge that gets missed in public discourse: it's not just that they make drones. It's that they've made India's security apparatus drone-literate. "We have had a very big role to play in operationalizing this technology, getting our forces used to using drones," Mehta says. The company's platforms are deployed across the Indian defense forces, central armed police forces, and state police agencies. In other words, ideaForge helped seed India's UAV doctrine before there even was one. Talk about being first!

And yet, Mehta is all too aware of how easily narratives can be hijacked.



ANKIT MEHTA
Co-founder & CEO,
ideaForge

"One of the biggest misconceptions is that everything we do is coming from China," he says. The problem isn't just geopolitical distrust, but a broader underestimation of domestic capability. "In 2022, we were visibly almost 50% of the Indian drone market, and we had almost nothing critical coming from China. None of the electronics was emanating from a Chinese source," he says emphatically.

Another persistent myth? That Indian drone tech is somehow inferior to its global counterparts. "There are very clearly certain categories where our performance, our experience, and our automation is actually better than the rest of the world," Mehta says. Case in point: one of ideaForge's quadcopters, weighing less than 7 kg, boasts a staggering 90-minute flight time. That's not just a good number. That's best-in-class globally, according to Ankit Mehta.

Part of ideaForge's design philosophy has been about distilling complexity into reliability. "Even a jawan can operate [our drones] without too much training," Mehta says. That's not an afterthought – it's the product. High reliability, high performance, and high